POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

Feel-Good Productivity

How to Do More of What Matters to You

Ali Abdaal · 2023

A doctor-turned-YouTuber makes the case that feeling good is the engine of productivity, not the reward for it, and gives research-backed experiments for bringing more energy into your work.[1,2]

WHY READ IT

- A warm, practical book that makes productivity feel lighter[2]
- Every chapter ends with small experiments to try[2]
- Clear explanations of the research behind each idea[1,3]

GET THE BOOK

Feel-Good Productivity by Ali Abdaal
Celadon Books (US); Cornerstone Press (UK), 2023. At your local bookshop, your library, or as an audiobook.

A free guide inspired by *Feel-Good Productivity* by Ali Abdaal. Not affiliated with the author or publisher.

Please read the book

THE BIG IDEA

Feeling good comes first

Abdaal argues the discipline-and-pressure approach has it backwards. Positive feelings give us energy, energy makes work easier to start and keep going, and progress then feels good too. So instead of forcing yourself to work, change how the work feels.[1,2,3]

THREE LESSONS

1 **Make it fun**

Ask: what would this look like if it were fun? Small changes, like music, a game, or doing it with someone, can transform a dull task.[3]

2 **Goals that energise**

Abdaal suggests NICE goals: Near-term, Input-based, Controllable and Energising, instead of distant targets you can't control.[2,4]

3 **Three kinds of burnout**

Overexertion (doing too much), depletion (not recharging) and misalignment (doing what doesn't fit you). Each needs a different fix.[2,3]

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THE FRAMEWORK

Energise · Unblock · Sustain[1,2]

The book's three parts: what gives us energy, what stops us starting, and what keeps us going.[1,2]

1 Energise

Play, Power and People

Lightness and curiosity, a sense of confidence and control, and feeling part of something with others.[2,3]

Try: Teach what you're learning to build confidence.[12]

2 Unblock

Uncertainty, Fear and Inertia

Seek clarity, find courage, and make starting easy.[2]

Try: Commit to just five minutes.[6]

3 Sustain

Conserve, Recharge, Align

Protect your energy, refill it, and make sure your work points where you want to go.[2,3]

Try: Sketch alternative futures with an Odyssey Plan.[5,9]

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FROM THE BOOK

Tools to try

Taming fear

Fear tools from the Unblock chapters, each borrowed and credited by Abdaal.[7]

1. Name the feeling in a word.
2. Ask how much it will matter in 10 minutes, 10 months and 10 years (Suzy Welch's 10/10/10).[8]
3. Remember the spotlight effect: others notice us far less than we think.[10]

The Energy Investment Portfolio

Abdaal's way to avoid overexertion.[5,11]

1. List every commitment and dream competing for your energy.
2. Choose about five active investments.
3. Move the rest to a someday list.
4. Review the portfolio each season.

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MAKE IT YOURS

Try it this week

1. Pick the task you've been avoiding most.
2. Change one thing to make it more fun.
3. Rewrite the goal as a NICE goal.
4. Set a five-minute timer and start.

REFLECT

Which blocker shows up most for you: uncertainty, fear or inertia?

Which kind of burnout are you closest to?

Try it in Sedi: Write the NICE goal on the task in Taskly and move it to In progress.

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READ THE BOOK

☀️ Feel-Good Productivity

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This guide only scratches the surface. The book has the research, the stories and the nuance behind every idea here. Buy it from an independent bookshop, borrow it from your library, or listen to the audiobook.

A NOTE FROM ME

I'm not affiliated with Ali Abdaal or the publisher, and this guide isn't sponsored or endorsed by them. I've learned a lot from this book, so I'm sharing what I took from it, for free, in case it helps you too. Everything here is my own summary, in my own words. The good ideas are the author's; any mistakes are mine.

The maker of Sedi

SOURCES

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